

Stealing Secrets: The International Spy Museum [C1]

Hai sempre sognato di fare l'agente segreto? In questo museo, situato a Washington D.C., potrai scoprire tutto sul mondo dello spionaggio, dai gadget alla crittoanalisi.



A lethal pen, a [purse](#) that [doubles as](#) a camera, and a ring with a [sharp](#) instrument hidden inside it. These are just some of the over ten thousand objects on show at the International Spy Museum in Washington, D.C. The museum has the world's largest collection of international espionage artefacts on [public display](#), and last year finished [consolidating](#) its collection in a new, temperature-controlled archive room. Initially opened in 2002 in Washington, D.C., the museum later relocated to a larger space in the district's commercial centre, L'Enfant Plaza, in 2019. A year later, it began [consolidating](#) its collection for the first time, in an archive room at the museum known as The [Vault](#). Although The [Vault](#) is a restricted area, many of its artefacts will be rotated into the museum's temporary and permanent exhibits. And there are plans to install special lighting so visitors can [peek](#) inside it in the future, and to create a digital interactive exhibit so people can view the complete collection online.

GLAMOUR AND INTRIGUE

To find out more about the museum and what it reveals about working in international espionage, Speak Up contacted the Director of Media Relations at the International Spy Museum, Aliza Bran. She began by reflecting on why espionage continues to captivate people around the world: **Aliza Bran (American accent):** I think everyone is curious about the things that they don't know, especially the things they're not supposed to know about, right? So there's something about being told you can't know something that makes you want it more. I think we're a little bit all [toddlers](#), just wanting all of the answers for ourselves. But what's great about it is, people get excited about the glamour and the intrigue of intelligence. But at the end of the day, it's really just global history through a different lens. So people [walk away](#) having learned a lot, even though it seems like just this incredibly entertaining space and experience.

THE POP APPROACH

Most of us access the world of intelligence and espionage through Hollywood movies. According to Bran, those glamorous [portrayals bear little resemblance](#) to reality, and one of the museum's goals is to help visitors see beyond the stereotypes. **Aliza Bran:** We do have one room on pop culture, and in our lobby we do have a 1969 Aston Martin from Goldfinger, because of course we recognise that's how people know our content best, is the movies and the pop culture of it all. But certainly a lot of that is quite [inaccurate](#) for the field itself. And what's interesting is, look, it's a lot of slower, quieter work that happens. It's incredibly impactful. In fact, some of the stories are even more bizarre than the Hollywood of it all. It's just a little bit different than you'd expect. The "Covert Action" gallery focuses on historical military deception.

CONCEAL AND COMMUNICATE

The museum's collection includes many unusual [devices](#). Among them are extraordinary examples of human [ingenuity](#) used to [conceal](#), communicate, and survive under the most challenging of circumstances. **Aliza Bran:** At the International Spy Museum we have a lot of [concealment devices](#). Things can be [concealed](#) in literally anything, whether we're talking a watch, a [briefcase](#)... I mean, again, a lot of that has been seen in the movies, of course. But one item that I have not seen out there that is unusual, [to say the least](#), is called a scrotum [concealment](#). I know that sounds [fairly silly](#), but at the time, people were not as intrusive with [body searches](#). So if you were in a bad situation and they took, you know, your clothes and everything on you, you could put the item [atop](#) your body and there would be a small radio in there so that you could communicate to get help.

ON THE FIELD AND BEHIND THE DESK

When we think of spies, we often imagine attractive agents [in disguise](#), using high-tech [devices](#) or escaping danger in fast vehicles. In reality, as Bran explained, the intelligence world includes many roles that range from high-risk fieldwork to meticulous and often boring data analysis. **Aliza Bran:** There are a lot of different things you can do within the intelligence community. I think there is a segment that is more of the adrenaline [seekers](#). That's people who have to be on the ground making the connections in uncomfortable situations and stressful situations. That's going to be people who are calm in times of stress. But you also have a lot of people who work in analysis. So that's people behind a desk [making sense](#) of large sets of data or a lot of information because when that information comes in, it's not really helpful intelligence if you can't make sense of it.

HOLLYWOOD IDEAS

So how much of what we see in films and TV dramas reflects the truth about the intelligence community? **Aliza Bran:** Some of the Hollywood of it is correct. A lot of it is not. There's this really interesting relationship between espionage and Hollywood. And not just the fact that people watch these crazy movies and shows and see some of the things that are in fact happening, but also the other way around. I talked to Jonna Mendez, one of our [board members](#) who formerly was the chief of disguise for the CIA. She was talking about how sometimes a show would come out and the team would come in on a Monday and they'd say, "Wow, you know, I just saw this over the weekend in a movie or in a television show. I wonder if we can do that or something like it." Current Affairs

The British Secret Service: MI6 I servizi segreti britannici sono considerati tra i più efficienti e raffinati al mondo. In più di un secolo di vita, nella realtà e nella finzione, dopo essere apparsi in numerosi romanzi e film, si sono costruiti una reputazione invidiabile. Daniel Francis

OPERATION BERNHARD

Among the over ten thousand artefacts that the International Spy Museum houses, Bran revealed her favourite is a piece of history that isn't a weapon or a deadly gadget, but a [token](#) of one of the most audacious covert operations ever attempted. **Aliza Bran:** One of my all-time favourite artefacts that we have on site is the Operation Bernhard [printing plate](#). This is going to sound a bit [nerdy](#), but during World War Two, the Nazis were actually trying to make a perfect [printing plate](#) that would look like British [currency](#). And they did so using prisoners in the concentration camps who had backgrounds in art, in [printmaking](#), in [metalwork](#), trying to basically create a perfect fake. They wanted to [take down](#) the British economy, and do so by [flooding](#) the economy with all of these fake British [notes](#). So it's just interesting, I think, that we found this [printing plate](#) underwater in an Austrian lake somewhere. But also it's interesting, it's not the kind of espionage operation that people think about. And so I think it [gives kind of breadth](#) to the understanding of what nations and groups can do who are participating in espionage and trying to [take down](#) another country in a [covert manner](#).

UNDERCOVER MISSION

The International Spy Museum is designed to immerse visitors in the world of intelligence, from the process of gathering information to [actionable intelligence](#). Its permanent exhibitions are structured to follow the steps a real spy would take. The visit begins in the Briefing Centre, where visitors receive a cover identity they are encouraged to maintain throughout their stay. Then, the section called Stealing Secrets focuses on the techniques spies use to gather information, including hundreds of authentic gadgets like miniature cameras, [concealment devices](#), [cipher](#) machines, and disguised weapons. Next comes Making Sense of Secrets, where visitors can [try their hand at code-cracking](#) and analysis to experience how [raw](#) data becomes useful intelligence. Finally, the section called Covert Action explores what happens after intelligence is processed, and even how leaders use it to influence events through covert missions, sabotage, propaganda, and even lethal operations. To make this journey more immersive, the museum offers an interactive challenge called Undercover Mission, which provides visitors with the opportunity to [walk in the shoes of](#) a real operative: **Aliza Bran:** We do have something called Undercover Mission, which is radio frequency identification (RFID)-based program throughout the museum. So people can participate if they want. You get a card, and through that, you get a

mission, a code name, and a code word for your visit. So throughout the museum, we have [peppered](#) different exhibit interactives. So people can design their own gadget, they can disguise themselves, they can do all sorts of different things. And [altogether](#), at the very end, we're able to tell them what their best spy skills are from having worked through all of those interactives. So it's a lot of fun. I would not make a great spy, but maybe you would. And that's how you can find out.
www.spymuseum.org

Glossary

- **walk in the shoes of** = mettersi nei panni di
- **consolidating** = consolidare
- **Vault** = caveau, camera blindata
- **walk away** = andare via
- **ingenuity** = ingegno
- **conceal** = nascondere, occultare
- **in disguise** = travestiti, mascherati
- **printmaking** = stampa, incisione
- **flooding** = inondare
- **peek** = sbirciare, dare un'occhiata
- **metalwork** = lavorazione dei metalli
- **notes** = banconote
- **take down** = distruggere
- **portrayals** = rappresentazioni
- **body searches** = perquisizioni corporali
- **actionable intelligence** = informazioni utili, operative
- **peppered** = cospargere
- **doubles as** = fungere anche da
- **sharp** = affilato
- **bear little resemblance** = hanno poco a che vedere
- **to say the least** = a dir poco
- **nerdy** = da secchioni
- **purse** = borsa
- **toddlers** = bambini piccoli
- **inaccurate** = inesatto
- **briefcase** = valigetta
- **atop** = sopra, in cima
- **printing plate** = lastra di stampa
- **public display** = esposizione pubblica
- **devices** = dispositivi
- **board members** = membri del consiglio di amministrazione
- **currency** = valuta, moneta
- **covert manner** = modo segreto
- **try their hand at** = cimentarsi
- **code-cracking** = crittoanalisi
- **raw** = grezzi, non elaborati
- **fairly silly** = piuttosto sciocco
- **token** = simbolo, ricordo
- **gives kind of breadth** = dare respiro, conferire ampiezza
- **cipher** = cifratura

- **altogether** = in generale
- **seekers** = cercatori
- **making sense** = dare un senso